

the undivided State, including Subroto Banerjee and Syed Saba Karim, have featured for India. However, after the formation of Jharkhand, Mahendra Singh Dhoni, Ishan Kishan, Shahbaz Nadeem and several others have represented the new State, even as Bihar remained suspended from the BCCI due to political infighting. In recent years, a couple of Bihar-born players like Mukesh Kumar and Akash Deep have represented India, but both played domestic cricket for Bengal.

Playing the ball, not the bowler

At the local level, the lack of serious competition made things relatively easy. But at the highest tier, the demands are far greater.

"The heavy bottom-hand domination is still there. There is a quick bat flow, but he manages it somehow," Ojha says, referring to the recent game against Royal Challengers Bengaluru, where his ward handled the seasoned Bhuvneshwar Kumar tactfully.

"When Vaibhav faced Bhuvneshwar's ball (second ball of Bhuvneshwar's second over), if he had shifted his whole body towards mid-on instead of opening up his back shoulder and keeping the bat's downswing right, he would have been out. But he controlled himself so well on the batwing that it became a six," Ojha explains.

"Even in the first over (of Bhuvneshwar), his backlift was so high, but he managed to connect the ball right next to his toe and it raced away for four," he adds.

Ojha admits he is often struck by how Sooryavanshi continues to thrive, finding answers even while carrying a clear technical flaw.

"We were expecting bowlers to target the gap that opens up between the bat and pad when you use a lot of bottom hand. You tend to go against your line and there is a possibility of getting out... In the IPL, there are so many big coaches and players, and we thought they would detect the loophole easily. But Vaibhav has managed it well. He has been able to work on it."

Sooryavanshi was the raging trend on social media after he fearlessly smashed Mumbai Indians' Bumrah for two sixes in an over. And, of course, there was no one happier than Ojha.

"It was a very proud moment," he says. "But a few things have to be taken into consideration here. Firstly, Vaibhav is a player who initiates. He is willing to take risks. Secondly, when he is making so many runs, his confidence is very high. And the third factor is that he sticks to his strategy and planning. Whatever target the team has, he is ready to strike from the very first ball," Ojha continues.

"If you let the bowler dominate your mind, then he will not let you bat. Especially at this level, if you start thinking about the bowler's face value, his records, his reputation, then you will not be able to play. You need to play by watching the ball and making your judgement according to its merit."

Despite being among the world's finest, Bumrah was left looking helpless against Sooryavanshi.

"Bumrah is a player with so many years of experience. But when Vaibhav hit that six, he was not playing Bumrah. He was playing Bumrah's ball. This mindset is instilled within him. It doesn't matter who is bowling," Ojha says.

It is a simple idea, but one that requires immense clarity to execute at the highest level. Perhaps that is what sets Sooryavanshi apart. The ability to remain anchored in the moment, to see the ball rather than the reputation attached to it, to trust instinct without losing structure.

The journey ahead will bring its own set of challenges, as every promising career inevitably does. That's why, for now, the essence remains unchanged.

The boy at Beckenham, asking for a few more minutes. The teenager unsure why people wanted his photograph. And the cricketer who, despite everything, still seems driven by that one simple desire.

"Abhi nahin... abhi toh thoda aur batting karna hai..."



Career timeline

2022-23

Breaks into Bihar U-19 side at just 12, for the Vinoo Mankad Trophy.

2023

Represents India B U-19 in a quadrangular series: 177 runs in six innings, including two fifties.

2024

January: First-class debut for Bihar vs Mumbai at 12 years, 284 days.

September: India U-19 debut vs Australia; scores a 58-ball century, second-fastest in U-19 internationals.

November: ACC U-19 Asia Cup: 76 (46) vs UAE; 67 (36) in semifinal vs Sri Lanka.

India A vs UAE (Rising Stars T20): 144 (42), century off 32 balls.

Becomes youngest T20 debutant (13y 241d) for Bihar in Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy.

Signed by Rajasthan Royals for Rs. 1.1 crore in IPL auction.

December: Youngest Indian List A debutant (13y 269d), vs Madhya Pradesh in Vijay Hazare Trophy.

2025

April 19: IPL debut for Rajasthan Royals vs Lucknow Super Giants (14y 23d).

April 28: Maiden IPL hundred, off 35 balls vs Gujarat Titans.

December: Vijay Hazare Trophy: 36-ball century vs Arunachal Pradesh; youngest List A centurion (14y 272d). Also breaks AB de Villiers' record for fastest 150 (59 balls).

2026

U-19 World Cup final: 175 (80) vs England (15 fours, 15 sixes); helps India to the title.